

Naming a Generation: How American Culture Writes Itself Into A Cradle

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Abstract

A baby name is a small cultural record of the year a child was born. Using the full state-level register of United States births from 1910 to 2014, together with the weekly Billboard Hot 100 since 1958 and a catalogue of HBO titles and cast credits, this report does two things for a creative agency. It measures how long popular names persist and tests the agency’s belief that persistence has weakened since the 1990s, and it traces the sudden surges in naming back to the singers and screen characters that set them off. Persistence has indeed loosened since 1990, at every horizon and most sharply for boys. The surges, meanwhile, line up closely with hit records and popular premieres, and an event study shows a name responding within a year or two of the moment that created it.

Table of Contents

Naming a generation	2
Naming persistence and the 1990s hypothesis	2
When a name suddenly arrives	4
The sound and the screen	7
Named after the charts	7
Named after the screen	8
How fast a culture names a child	9
What names follow	10

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Naming a generation

A baby name carries the fingerprint of its moment. It records what its parents were listening to, watching and talking about in the year the child arrived. With the full American birth register from 1910 to 2014, alongside the Billboard Hot 100 and a catalogue of HBO titles, that record can be read two ways. The first asks how durable a popular name is, and whether durability has weakened. The second asks what lifts a new name into use, and how quickly it answers.

Naming persistence and the 1990s hypothesis

Persistence is measured by taking each year's 25 most popular names for a gender and comparing their ranking to the same names one, two and three years later. A Spearman rank correlation near one means the order held, a lower value means the names moved or fell away.

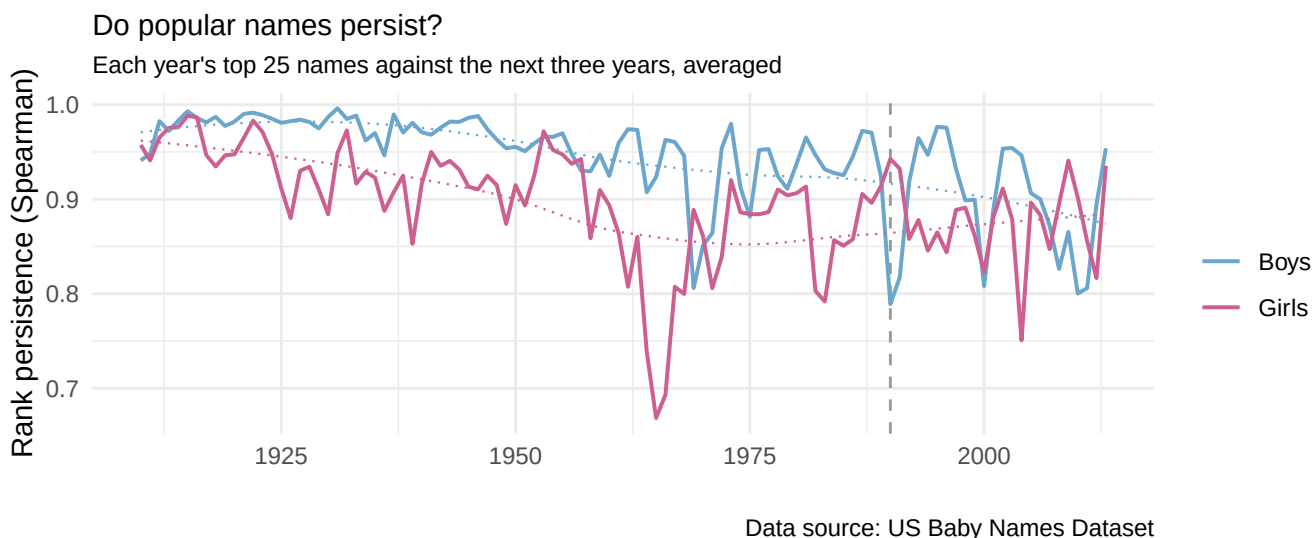


Figure 1: Rank persistence of the top 25 names, each year against the next three. The dashed line marks 1990.

Table 1: Mean rank persistence by gender and horizon, before and from 1990

Gender	Horizon	Pre-1990	1990 onward	Change
Boys	1-year	0.981	0.950	-0.031
Boys	2-year	0.958	0.891	-0.067
Boys	3-year	0.934	0.836	-0.098
Girls	1-year	0.952	0.937	-0.014
Girls	2-year	0.900	0.868	-0.032
Girls	3-year	0.853	0.815	-0.038

- The agency’s suspicion holds. Persistence falls after 1990 in every cell of the table, for both genders and at all three horizons.
- The effect grows with distance. For boys the three-year persistence drops from 0.934 to 0.836, the largest fall in the table, so the further ahead you look the more a modern top name has moved.
- Girls’ names were always looser and slip less, from 0.853 to 0.815 at three years, so the change is real but gentler than for boys.
- For the agency this means a name borrowed from today’s culture is a weaker long-term bet than it would have been a generation ago, which is exactly what the surge analysis below explains.

Fashion does not stop at the whole name, it reaches down to the opening letter. Figure 2 maps the share of births starting with each letter across the decades, and whole rows brighten and dim as initials move in and out of favour. The turnover at the level of a single letter mirrors the turnover in the names themselves, which is a quiet confirmation that naming is governed by fashion almost everywhere one looks.

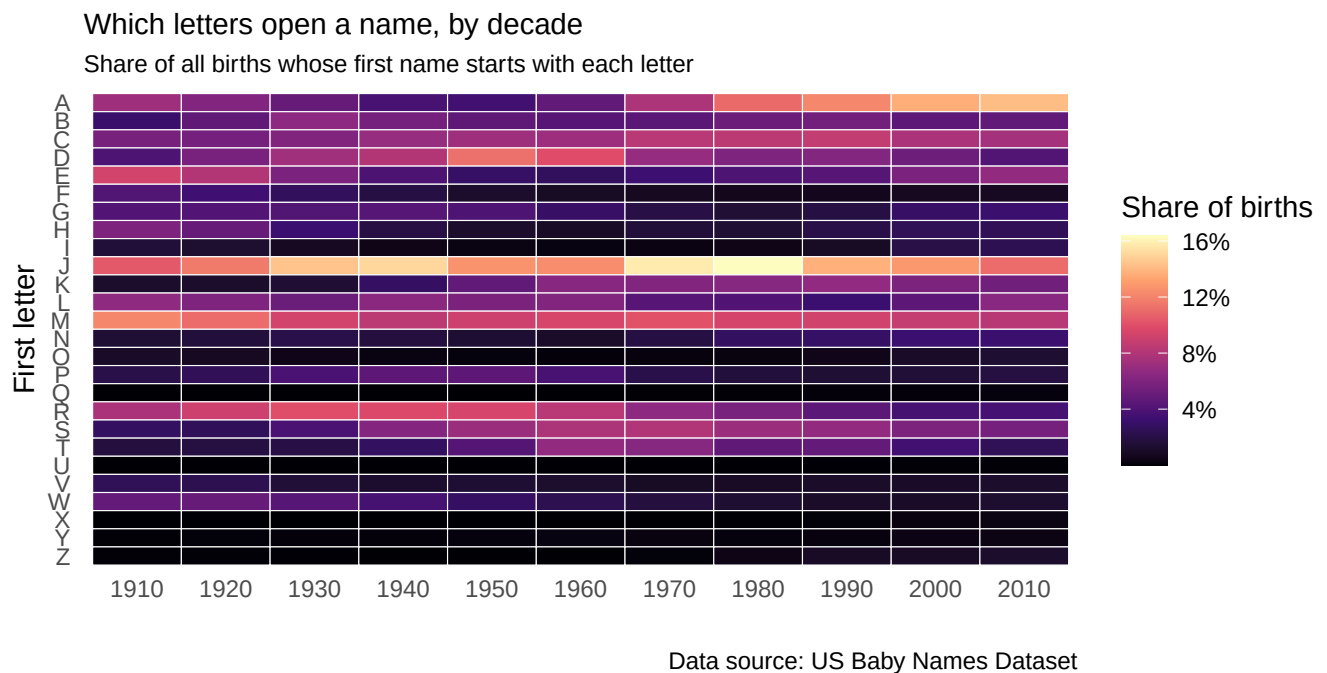


Figure 2: Share of births by opening letter, across decades.

Length carries its own quiet history. Figure 3 stacks the distribution of name length for each decade, weighted by births so the ridges reflect babies rather than rare names. The weighted mean climbs from about 5.7 letters through the middle of the century to roughly 6.2 in the 1980s and 1990s before

easing back toward 5.9, so the long American name was a late-century fashion that has since softened rather than a permanent shift.

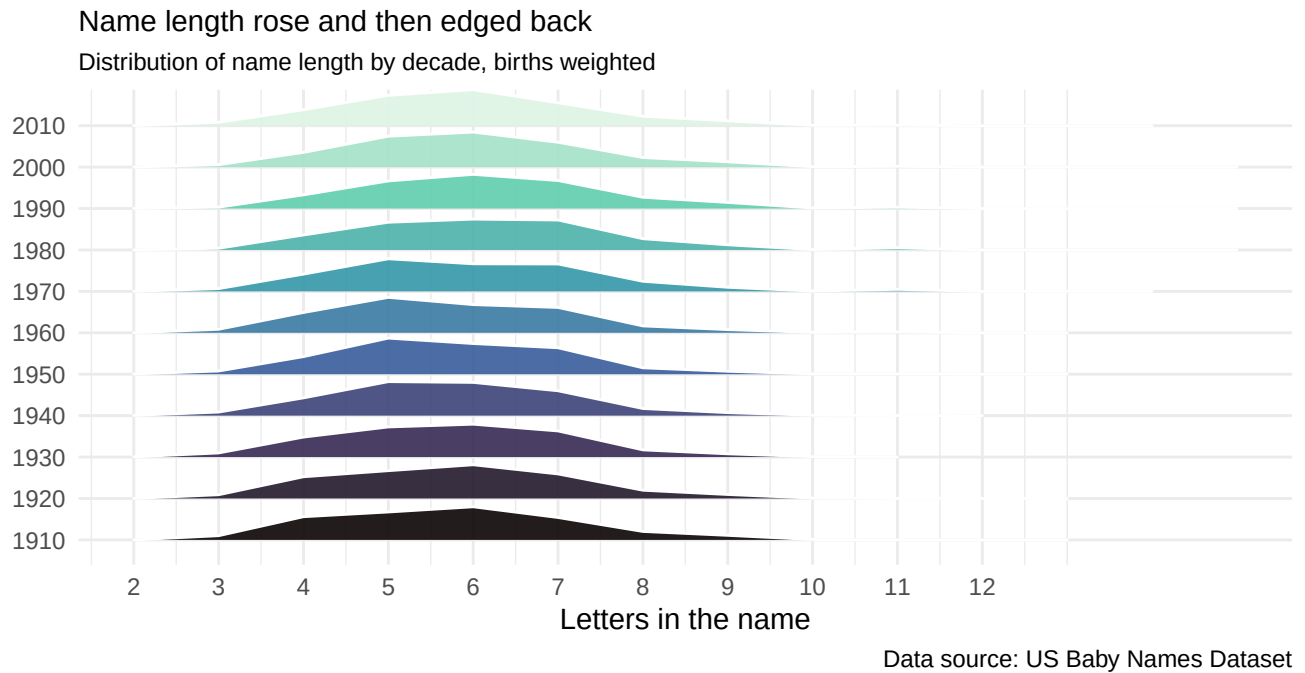


Figure 3: Name length distribution by decade, births weighted.

When a name suddenly arrives

The sharpest movements in naming are not drifts but spikes, and they can be found directly in the data as large year-on-year jumps. The most significant are striking, and many sit on a clear cultural event.

Table 2: The ten sharpest year-on-year name surges, with the cause our datasets can attribute

Year	Name	Before	After	Times bigger	Cause
1972	Katina	48	2726	56.8	Other
1983	Marquita	96	2522	26.3	Other
1966	Audra	36	865	24.0	Other
1976	Farrah	36	813	22.6	Other
1912	Woodrow	82	1826	22.3	Other
2001	Nevaeh	53	1179	22.2	Other
1957	Tammy	204	4363	21.4	Other
1954	Sheree	35	646	18.5	Other
1992	Devante	86	1551	18.0	Other
1994	Aliyah	43	707	16.4	Other

The supervisor's chart sets these out by name and year, sized by how many babies took the name, with colour marking whether a singer or a screen character drove it.

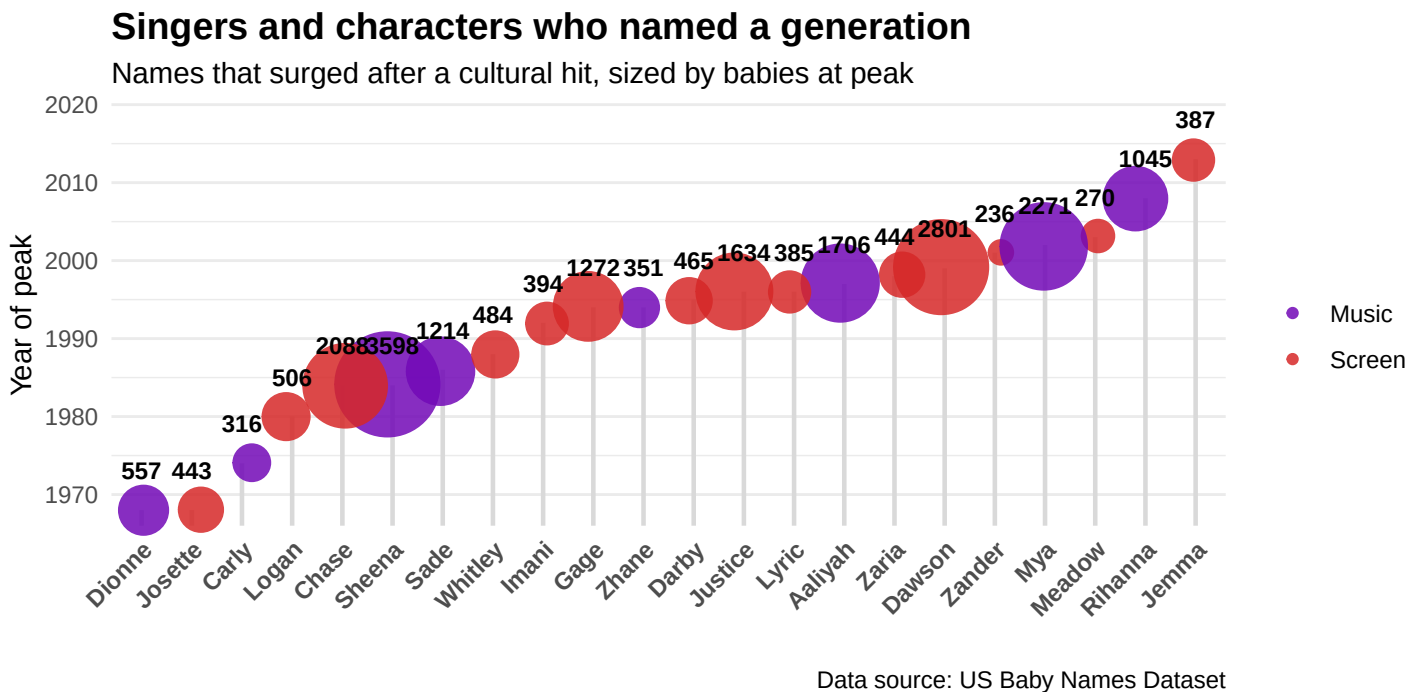


Figure 4: Names that surged after a hit record or a screen premiere, sized by babies at their peak.

A surge is not the same as a lasting name. Plotting the largest surges over their full life shows that most are fashions that fade within a decade.

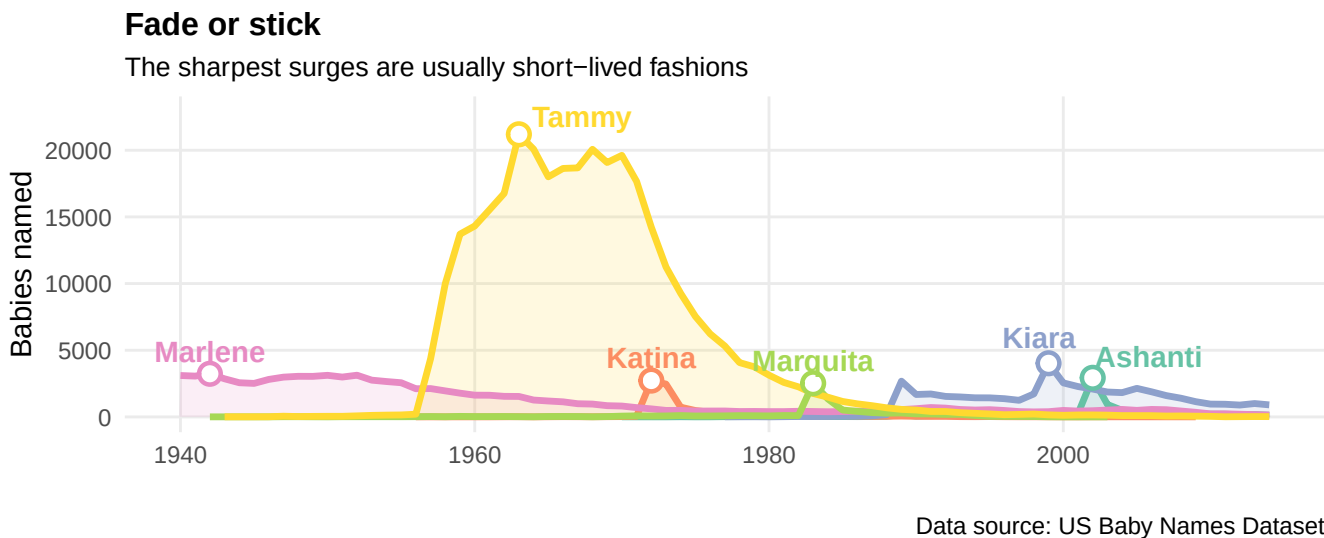


Figure 5: The full trajectory of the sharpest surges. Most rise steeply and fall almost as fast.

- The surges are real and large. The sharpest, Katina in 1972, multiplied more than fifty times in a single year off the back of a television character.
- Most of them fade. The same names that spike fastest tend to collapse within a few years, which is the surge-level reflection of the falling persistence in the previous section.
- Colour ties cause to effect. Where our datasets reach the moment, screen characters and singers account for the surge, and the rest sit unexplained, waiting for the deeper look that follows.

A complementary view turns to the biggest names of the past century and scales each to its own peak, so the shape of each rise and fall can be read directly.

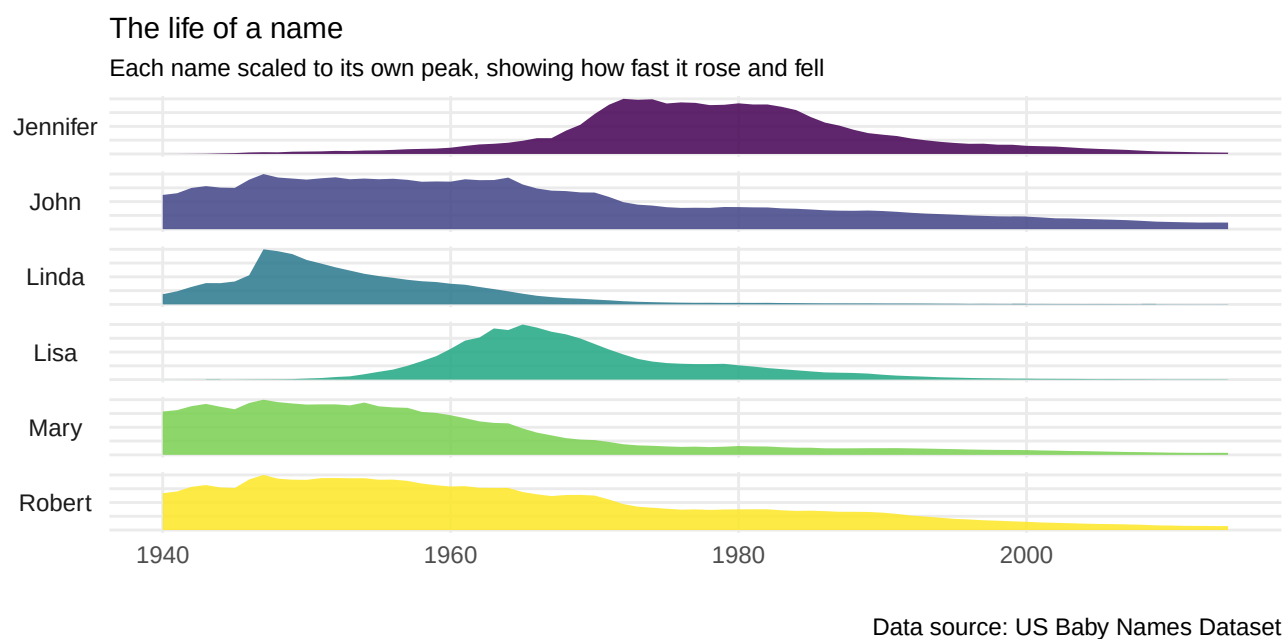


Figure 6: The life of several culture-driven names, each scaled to its own peak.

- Even the giants are temporary. Linda and Lisa tower over their decades and then all but vanish, each now a fraction of a percent of its own peak.
- This is the persistence finding seen one name at a time. No name holds the top for long, the same impermanence the Spearman series measured in aggregate.

The spread of names is not only about which ones rise, it is about how thinly births are spread across all of them. Figure 7 tracks the share of babies carrying one of the ten most popular names each year, fitted with a linear trend. The concentration falls from roughly nineteen percent in 1910 to under six percent by 2014, so parents now draw from a far wider pool and the very top names command a shrinking slice of each cohort.

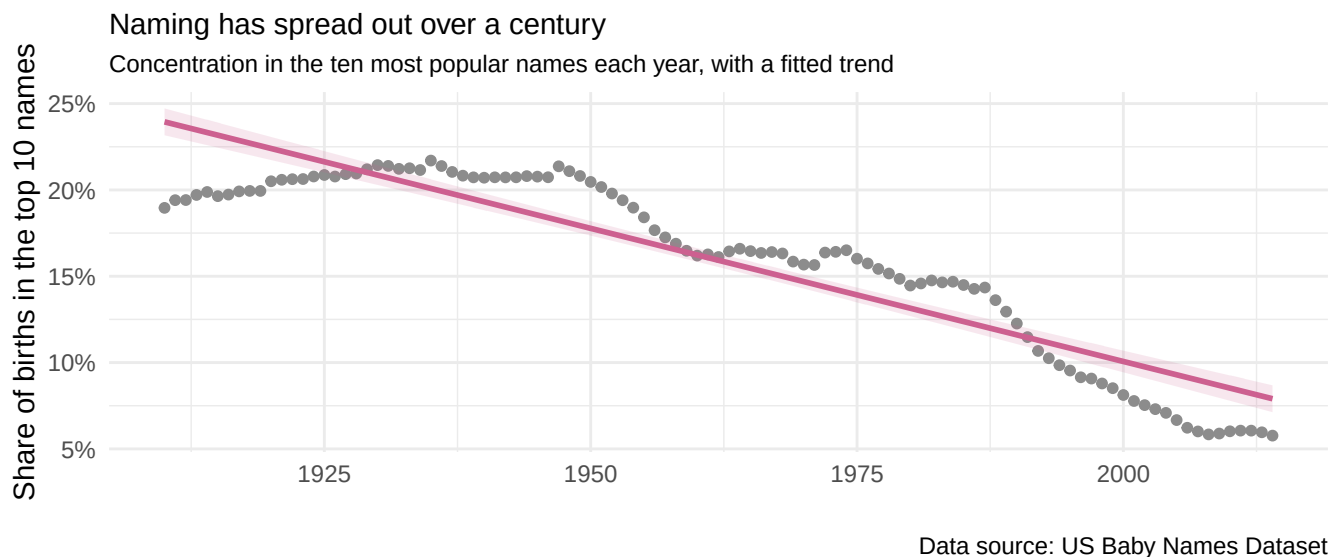


Figure 7: Share of births held by the ten most popular names each year.

The sound and the screen

The surge view points at music and television without proving them. The Billboard and HBO datasets let us test both directly, by reading the first name of every charting act and every screen character and asking whether babies followed.

Named after the charts

Table 3: Singers whose first name surged in babies after they first reached the Billboard top ten

Name	Artist	First charted	Before	Peak	Times bigger
Sade	Sade	1985	0	1214	1214.0
Rihanna	Rihanna	2005	0	1045	1045.0
Zhane	Zhane	1993	0	351	351.0
Aaliyah	Aaliyah	1994	5	1706	284.3
Carly	Carly Simon	1971	5	316	52.7
Sheena	Sheena Easton	1981	90	3598	39.7
Dionne	Dionne Warwick	1964	18	557	29.8
Mya	Mya & Sisqo	1998	101	2271	22.3

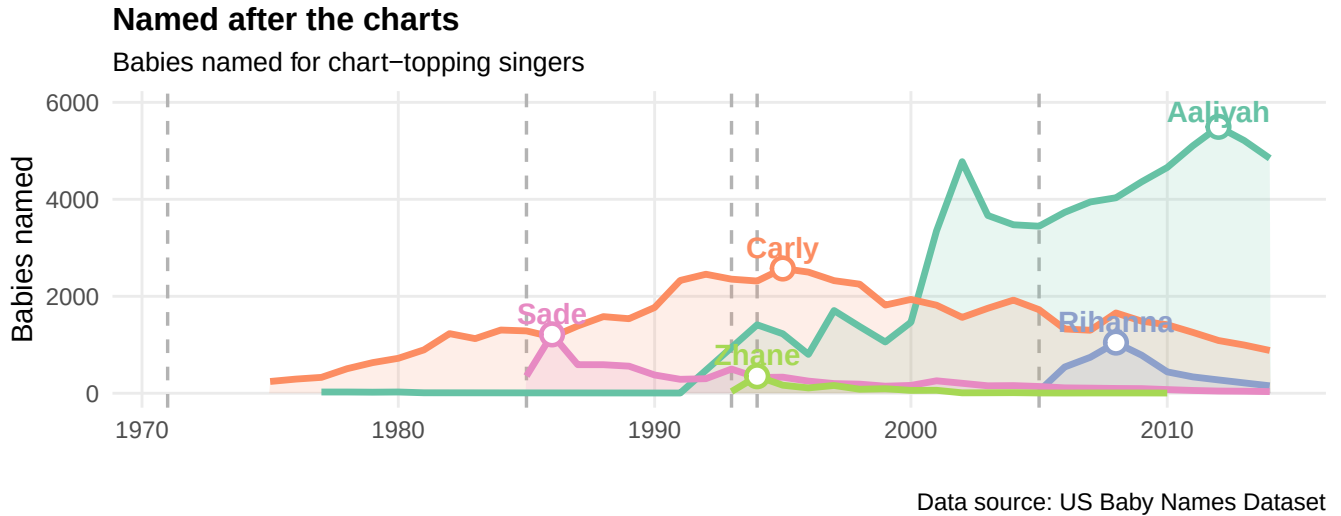


Figure 8: Naming after the charts. Dotted lines mark the year each act first reached the top ten.

- The chart all but creates names. Sade and Rihanna barely existed before their first hit and then ran into the thousands, with Aaliyah close behind, while Zhane and Carly show the same shape on a smaller scale.
- The brief's Whitney example is the same mechanism in a milder form. Whitney was already a known name, 1,547 births in 1982, and Houston lifted it more than sixfold to 9,719 by 1986. Because it was already common it sits just outside a table built to surface names the charts created from almost nothing.

Named after the screen

Table 4: Screen characters whose first name surged in babies after the title appeared

Name	Title	Released	Score	Peak	Times bigger
Whitley	A Different World	1987	6.7	484	484.0
Zaria	The Parent 'Hood	1995	6.4	444	444.0
Meadow	The Sopranos	1999	8.5	270	270.0
Zander	Starship Troopers	1997	7.0	236	236.0
Lyric	Jason's Lyric	1994	6.6	385	64.2
Justice	The Pelican Brief	1993	6.6	1634	29.5
Imani	Coming to America	1988	6.8	394	28.1
Gage	Tales from the Darkside: The Movie	1990	6.1	1272	25.6

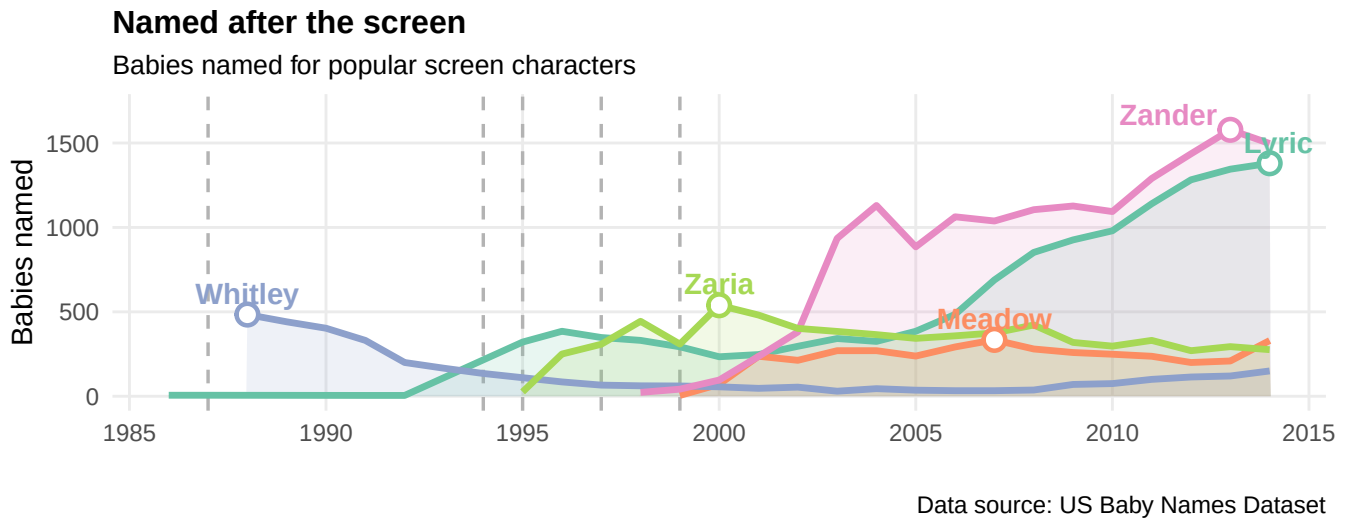


Figure 9: Naming after the screen. Dotted lines mark each title's release year.

- Characters travel from the screen into the register. Meadow rises after *The Sopranos*, Whitley after *A Different World*, and Imani after *Coming to America*, each within a year or two of the title appearing.
- The supervisor's Katina is the same mechanism a generation earlier, a character name that arrived the moment the show did.
- A caution on the source. The HBO catalogue includes films streamed on the service, not only its own productions, so entries like Zander or Lyric are candidate associations rather than proven causes. The strongest cases are the distinctive names tied to genuinely popular, character-led shows.

How fast a culture names a child

Pooling every matched name and lining each one up on the year its trigger landed gives an event study, the average naming response to a hit or a premiere. Each name is scaled to its own peak, so the curve reads as the share of a name's eventual high point reached at each step from the event.

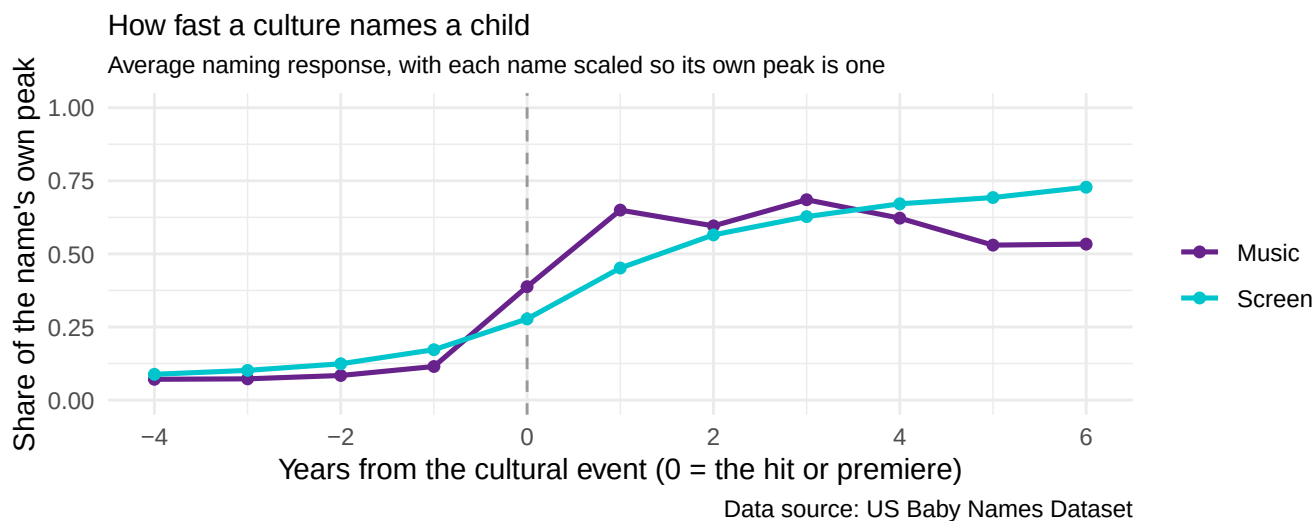


Figure 10: Average naming response around the cultural event, music against screen.

- The event is the hinge. Both music and screen names sit near a tenth of their peak in the years before, then turn upward the moment the hit or premiere lands.
- Music is fast and front-loaded. A charting name reaches roughly two thirds of its peak within a single year and tops out inside three, matching a song's instant, saturating reach before it fades.
- Screen is slow and durable. A character name climbs gently and is still rising six years on, which fits a show that builds its audience season by season.
- Either way the response is quick. Within a year or two of the moment the name is already well on its way, so naming tracks culture almost in real time.

What names follow

Two findings sit together. Popular names hold their place less firmly than they once did, especially for boys and especially since 1990, so any name the agency borrows from culture should be treated as a moving target. And the thing that moves it is close cultural reach, the singers on the charts and the characters on the screen, whose names enter the register within a year or two and then, more often than not, recede again. A name is a fashion with a date stamp, and the data shows both the stamp and the fading ink.